

Great African kingdoms

Between the 15th and 18th centuries, great kingdoms continued to flourish across Africa. The expansion of trade networks brought considerable wealth, and the architecture and artworks that survive from this time are evidence that the continent was home to many rich cultures.

Several African kingdoms grew rich as a result of the continent's booming trade networks, which expanded as far as Europe, Asia, and the Americas. The trading strategy in each kingdom was different. Some rulers focused on controlling regional trade, while others dominated the growing international networks. There was the centuries-old trade across the Sahara Desert as well as the emerging Atlantic trade with Europeans, which included the exchange of gold, ivory, salt, and enslaved people (see pp.132–133).

The great wealth of these African kingdoms meant that money could be spent on improving the kingdom

itself. Some kingdoms used their wealth to equip, organize, and train their military forces, to allow them to conquer neighboring countries and extend the boundaries of their empires. This greater military might also protected them from attempts at colonization, as Europeans began to take more of an interest in the resources of the continent.

QUEEN MOTHER IDIA



Queen Mother Idia was an important figure in the wealthy Kingdom of Benin, in modern-day Nigeria. She was the mother of the Oba (king) and she helped her son defeat his enemies.

Small brass soldiers surround the central figure of military commander Ehenua.

BENIN EMPIRE ►
Art flourished in the Kingdom of Benin and these round "ikegobo" (altars to the hand) were made to celebrate a person's achievements. This one was created to honor the heroism of Ehenua, an 18th-century military commander who served under Oba Akenzua I.

FACT

Timbuktu, the capital of the Mali Empire, was an important religious, educational, and trading center. In 1500, its population of 100,000 included scholars, artists, and scientists.

